

Just a matter of time: reviewing temporality in Australian historiography

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Abstract

Time is a foundational concept in historical studies. The past is located 'in time', of course, such that time guides and bounds 'what happened' to a 'when'. There have also been increasing theorisations that understand 'time' itself as temporally and culturally bound. As well as historicising, then, time itself must be historicised. Using Australian historiography as a case study, this paper explores the changing concept of 'time' over time. It sets out a provisional timeline of Australian history's understanding and deployment of historical time, contributing a much-needed historicisation of time to a growing field of historical theory. In charting a history of time in Australian historiography, it demonstrates the historicity of 'time'. This paper shows how the concept of time not only reflects, but in turn shapes and defines, historical practice and research.

Introduction

In his 1995 study of history, *Silencing the Past: Power and the Production of History*, Michel-Rolph Trouillot insisted on the need to recognise the discipline's power to curate and control. Critical, structural analysis of history-making would expose not only the past under examination, he contended, but the form and function of the discipline over time: what 'history is changes with time and place', such that 'history reveals itself only through the production of such narratives' (Trouillot 1995, 25). Trouillot's intervention reflected foundational shifts in historical practice and theory galvanised by work in postcolonial and settler-colonial studies, for example, as well as Indigenous readings of the past and historical perspectives contextualised by trans-Atlantic slavery. This is a vast, diverse body of work, to be sure, produced across continents and over decades. Yet at its core is a vital acknowledgement that the history discipline is not neutral: archives silence as well as record; history renders some practitioners visible while ignoring others; and concepts of historical 'truth' can exclude Indigenous and sub-altern truths (Spivak 1988; Wolfe 2016; Stoler 2010; Moreton-Robinson 2015; Deloria 2020; Chakrabarty 2010; King 2020).

History—a Western, empirical discipline founded on concepts of objectivity and evidence—has become increasingly understood as conditional and conditioning. Even the concepts themselves, seemingly concrete and fixed, have become subjects of sustained study that reveals the mutability of their meaning and operation. As Peter Novick's treatment of objectivity in American history confirms, the field has been defined by constantly shifting boundaries, values, and methods, such that 'objectivity' itself must be understood as a 'contested concept whose meaning changes over time' (Novick 1988, 1). Ideas of 'truth' and 'evidence' have been similarly read as culturally and temporally relative (Novick 1988; Curthoys and Docker 2005; Griffiths 2016; Stoler 2010).

Even the notion of ‘time’, so fundamental to disciplinary practice and theory, is widely understood as contingent by leading historical theoreticians (Leyden 1963, 263). ‘Time’, that confident marker of historical events, not only plots, measures and sequences the past, but shapes our experiences and understandings of it. Studies of time have confirmed the subjectivity of an individual’s ‘temporal “setting”’, in David Carr’s words (2001, 158). How people experience the past depends on when, where, and how they live it. Meanwhile, a growing body of work has also offered important theorisation and contemplation of how time functions in modern historiography. Reinhardt Koselleck’s field-defining work on ‘temporalisation’, in which he argued that the emergence of modern time (from 1750-1850) created different relationships between modern society and the past, in turn demonstrated how modernity effected particular understandings and expressions of historical practice and theory (Koselleck 1985; Hellerma 2020). That is not to say temporalising time is an easy task, Koselleck (1985, xxi) acknowledged: ‘The question of what historical time might be belongs to those questions which historical science has the most difficulty answering.’ A generation later, the question has become no less urgent, as Berber Bevernage and Chris Lorenz contend. Theorising ‘the “historical relativity” of time’ remains vital to understanding the history of our disciplinary enterprise. Time is ‘essential to historiography’, they insist (Bevernage and Lorenz 2013, 7, 13).

This paper takes up Koselleck, Bevernage and Lorenz’s entreaties to contemplate the concept of time, but does so in a very contextualised, grounded way. Using Australian historiography as a case study, it looks at how time has been understood and deployed in modern historical practice. This approach was chosen for several reasons. The first is practical: while my interests extend to world historiography and historical theory, telling ‘a story’ of ‘historical time’ seemed more manageable within the frame of a specific site study—and Australia was an obvious

choice, given I am based here. This conscious act of location, I hope, gives the analysis depth and focus, rather than exacerbating any shallow parochialism.

Secondly, as others have noted elsewhere, the emergence of ‘Australian history’ coincided with the emergence of the modern history discipline in the mid- to late-nineteenth century (Boucher 2009; Attwood 2017). So a reading of ‘time’ in Australian historiography provides a unique context to investigate discrete themes and ideas *over time* within a modern disciplinary frame. For example, colonial histories that charted the ‘beginnings’ of Australian history were replaced over the course of the nineteenth century by more ‘national’ histories, in which a newly professionalised history discipline was increasingly called upon to chart the ‘progress’ of the emerging nation. Both historiographical periods deployed historical time in identifiable ways.

Finally, as in many settler-colonial states around the world, historians in Australia have increasingly grappled with acknowledging that their discipline has been complicit in the colonisation of Indigenous peoples—policing whose histories can be told, and how. ‘Time’ has been a critical component of that colonising architecture—determining Indigenous people had ‘no time’, or existed outside historical, linear time (and therefore outside historical ‘progress’). Indigenous histories and historians were largely excluded from Australian historiography until the latter decades of the twentieth century. Since then, calls for the recognition of Indigenous histories have radically shifted disciplinary understandings, including conceptions of time. Such histories have pushed the timeline of Australian history into the deep past (tens of thousands of years ago), as well as challenging the history profession to engage with Indigenous temporalities. This space is not unique to Australia, as the recent statement on decolonising research by the *American Historical Review* makes clear (AHR 2018). Indeed, the ethical demand to engage with, acknowledge and include Indigenous knowledges has extended the discipline into

new, albeit sometimes challenging, epistemological territory internationally (Tuhiwai Smith 2012; Marker 2019; Deloria 2020; Johnson 2014).

My case study approach to elucidate the temporality of historical time in the Australian context builds on existing models of scholarship. Sarah Pinto's important survey of the history of emotions in Australia, for example, demonstrated how a global body of work has been adopted and applied locally over several decades (Pinto 2017). Meanwhile, Bain Attwood's (2017) field-defining analysis of historical denial in Australia traced not only how history excluded Indigenous perspectives for the better part of a century, but how the discipline itself facilitated that silencing. Such papers show how complex, theoretical and international fields of historical research can be usefully located in national discussions.

This paper offers the beginnings of a history of 'time' in Australian historiography, which I define as that body of disciplinary history conforming to recognisable, authorised conventions of empirical research that is focused on the continent now known as Australia (Woolf 2011). (Although, it is important to note that even the place-name of this historiography has changed over time—from 'New Holland', to 'New South Wales', to 'Australia', not to mention the millennia of history-making that took place on this continent before modern historiography was even broadly defined.) In doing so, it identifies three main periods of historical time: colonising time, national time, and most recently, a critical interrogation of time influenced by Indigenous histories, which I tentatively term 'decolonising time'. Each occupies a relatively identifiable time-period and includes a recognisable body of scholarship. Although I also acknowledge that the definition of 'historiography' itself has been challenged in this latter period of revision and critique—indeed, that recognition forms part of my analysis. Furthermore, these periods are meant to be indicative rather than prescriptive. In setting out a provisional timeline of Australian

history's understanding and deployment of historical time, however, this paper contributes a much-needed historicisation of time to a growing field of historical theory.

Restrictions of space (and time!) inherently confine this paper to a survey of the field, although I note that efforts are increasingly being made to disrupt and hybridise the history discipline to accommodate diverse epistemologies and temporalities (eg. Clossey et al 2016; 2017). While resisting the prescription of any one particular disciplinary approach, this survey nevertheless hints at some of the possibilities of disciplinary change, as well as prompting conversation that others might take up in subsequent research. In charting a history of time in Australian historiography, it demonstrates the historicity of 'time'. In doing so, it shows how the concept of time not only reflects, but in turn shapes and defines, historical practice and research.

Colonising time

When Dipesh Chakrabarty (2011, 247) described colonisation as 'a moment of encounter between history-rich and history-poor peoples', he implicitly marked not only a moment *in* time (of contact/colonisation), but also a moment of historical temporality. Chakrabarty's comments were not a judgement that Indigenous peoples lacked historical consciousness, but that their forms of history-making and historical subjectivity were not recognised in empirical disciplinary models. His assessment is evident in early colonial histories of Australia, which are characterised by assumptions that Indigenous peoples had no 'history' and therefore existed outside historical temporality.

In the early decades of Australia's colonisation its historical texts were often the journals of maritime explorers or the writings of marines sent to guard the British penal colony (Cook 1768-71; Banks 1896; Parkinson 1773). Yet they had a strong sense they were writing 'history', and the First Fleet Officer Watkin Tench (1998, 4)

defined his account in those terms explicitly. Commercial and popular appetite for information about this ‘new continent’ was such that several texts were commissioned *before* Australia was even colonised, and several of these accounts of the remote convict settlement were translated into French, German and Swedish (Wantrup 1988). In one such example, as the First Fleet set sail to Australia in 1787, curious consumers were sated with publication of *A History of New Holland, from its Discovery in 1616, to the Present Time*. This history, mostly copied from the exploration journals of William Dampier and James Cook, charts the beginnings of New Holland’s history from European exploration.

These colonial histories constantly divided Australian history into ‘before’ and ‘after’ European ‘discovery’. Before colonisation Australian was unknown, a rumour even, as *The History of New Holland* (1787, 1-2) explains: ‘New Holland was, for upwards of a century, supposed to be a part of a vast Southern continent, the existence of which had been long a favourite idea, maintained, on various reasoning, by many experienced navigators, as well as speculative arguers.’ The idea that Australia was little more than a Western hunch is a recurring motif in much of its historiography—even into the twentieth century (Brodie 2016, 64). On the first page of his 1837 history of New South Wales, for example, the influential public and political figure John Dunmore Lang wrote that the ‘vast continental island’ now known as Australia ‘was long supposed by European philosophers to constitute a part of an imaginary southern continent’ (Lang 1837, 1). The opening lines of Ernest Scott’s 1916 *Short History of Australia*, a widely-used school text, similarly described that incomplete view of the world prior to ‘discovery’: ‘There was a period when maps of the world were published whereon the part occupied by the continent of Australia was a blank space’ (Scott 1916, 1).

Emigrants’ guides for British imperial entrepreneurs (and their subsequent colonial memoirs) also gave vital accounts of the colony’s ‘young history’ during this

colonial period. Like self-described colonial histories, such texts emphasised the schism between the continent's historied and unhistoried past. This was 'a country without a yesterday', Godfrey Charles Mundy insisted in his 1852 (623) reflections on the colony. To be fair, as the historian Mark McKenna has observed, colonisation *did* mark the foundation of colonial history. Yet at the same time, beginning Australian history with colonisation essentially authorised that colonial presence by implying that what had come before was unknowable and unremarkable. 'From the moment of first contact, a narrative was required that interpreted the invader's presence and legitimacy in relation to an Aboriginal presence', McKenna (2011, 132) contended. Indigenous Australia might have had an improbably long past, but it did not have 'history' in that disciplinary sense.

In those same texts, the idea of Australia's pre-colonial historical 'blankness' is counterposed with the colonists' industry and agency which 'filled in' the continent with buildings, infrastructure and people, as well as historical accounts of it all. In his First Fleet journal, the Judge Advocate David Collins emphasised the replacement of silence with colonial noise in the earliest days of the colony, when a site for the settlement was chosen in a secluded cove on Gadigal Country in what is now Sydney Harbour:

The spot chosen for this purpose was at the head of the Cove near a run of fresh water, which stole silently through a very thick wood, the stillness of which had then, for the first time since the creation, been interrupted by the rude sound of the labourer's axe, and the downfall of its ancient inhabitants:- a stillness and tranquility which, from that day, were to give place to the noise of labour, the confusion of camps and towns, and the busy hum of its new possessors (Collins 1804, 10).

George Hamilton's nineteenth century historical reminiscences, published a generation later, revealed similar assumptions about Australia's Indigenous past: 'Generation after generation of wild savages had roamed these valleys and gullies—had hunted, fought, corroborried on them, and passed away unheeded by the world', Hamilton (1880, 38) had mused. 'Here was a country without a geography, and a race of men without a history.'

Comparisons between Indigenous Australia's 'blankness' and colonial industry and progress enabled historians to narrate the inevitability of Australia's discovery and colonisation. British imperialism even provided a structure to explain the continent's colonisation as providential, as Lang's (1837, 465) history of New South Wales explained: 'I should sooner doubt the fact of my own existence, than doubt that the happiness and prosperity of the British nation are indissolubly connected with the pursuance of a course, which Divine Providence has made so clearly imperative, and on which the true glory of the nation so evidently depends.' James Bonwick's 1882 history of the early colony reiterated that logic of divine inevitability. 'Being in the finest part of the temperate zone, and only inhabited by a few savages, the country seemed marked by Providence for British colonisation', he surmised (Bonwick 1882, 2).

Over time, that sense of colonial entitlement was not simply providential, but 'evidenced' by history itself: the colony's endless expansion, its inexorable political, economic and cultural development, filled the pages of later histories from the colonial period. These texts present staggering leaps of progress and advancement for the young colony. 'One thousand and thirty individuals, chiefly male and female convicts, formed the nucleus of the Australasian colonies, and their pastoral career was simultaneously commenced by an importation on the part of the government of seven horses and six horned cattle', William Westgarth wrote in 1848. And yet, he continued, 'These settlements now contain a population of nearly 300,000 colonists,

with two millions of horned cattle. There are also twelve million sheep, including those of all ages, and 150,000 horses' (Westgarth 1848, 2-3). In his 1870 *Handbook to New South Wales*, Frederic Algar (1870, 2) was similarly effusive: 'The history of New South Wales, if brief, is eventful, and there are three distinct eras, which mark its progress from a miserable convict station, to one of the most prosperous provinces of the British Empire.'

In marking historical time as progress, colonial historiography gave this period of 'colonising time' a temporal logic of legitimacy, but also of replacement. As Denis Byrne (1996, 91) has argued, 'unilinear models of human progress already being advanced in the mid-eighteenth century allowed the non-Western world to serve as evidence of the West's prehistory'. That constant demarcation of what was rightfully part of Australia's history tacitly determined what could be left out. Over the course of the nineteenth century, Australian historiography increasingly excluded Indigenous history. 'Settler history is full of life, full of "firsts"', Grace Karskens (2019, 105) acknowledged. 'But Aboriginal history is usually presented as the flipside of this: it is stalked by death, marked out by a mournful litany of "lasts".'

In the earliest histories of Australia, historical time was understood to begin at the point of European 'discovery'. Before that, the continent was in a sense 'timeless'—and certainly devoid of history in a disciplinary sense. By marking out time in this way, Paul Carter (1987, xx) observed, colonial histories gave the colony an origin story and a legitimization. Aboriginal people 'were not physically invisible, but they were culturally so, for they eluded the cause-and-effect logic that made the workings of history plain to see', he writes. 'They did not share history's celestial viewpoint.'

For a long time, these diaries, travelogues, memoirs and guides were known as Australia's 'first histories', dutifully describing the colony's daily life, including the huge challenges of isolation, starvation, and precarity, as well as genuine curiosity

about the place in which they had arrived and the Indigenous people they now lived alongside. Such texts were produced before the discipline's late nineteenth century professionalisation, with increasingly verified methods of 'scientific' evidence and objectivity, as well as qualifications of expertise. Yet these early historical works were critical for the way they 'read' Australian history and registered its borders. The temporality of this historiographical period was clear, demarcating historical time in ways that diminished Indigenous histories that had played out across the entire continent for tens of thousands of years. Australia's historiographical emptiness prior to colonisation—its 'historylessness' as the postcolonial studies scholar Lorenzo Veracini (2007) evocatively describes it—reflected the enduring assumption that pre-colonial Australia was also pre-historical.

National Time

By the end of the nineteenth century, Australian historiography's early emphasis on Providence was increasingly superseded by a more national, scientific (but no less hyperbolic) focus on progress. There were two reasons for this shift. The first was growing Australian nationalism, which found expression as a popular and political independence movement to unify the six colonies across the continent. After a century of British oversight, a burgeoning Australian consciousness coalesced into momentum for statehood. This sense of national distinctiveness locally also had broader context. Global ideologies of nationalism came to prominence in the nineteenth century and understood 'the nation' as the organic basis of culture, identity, and government. History was key to those expressions of national identity, as Eric Hobsbawm and David Kertzer (1992, 3) have noted. 'Nations without a past are contradictions in terms', they wrote. 'What makes a nation is the past, what justifies one nation against others is the past, and historians are the people who

produce it.' Australian historiography was explicitly framed by this late nineteenth century moment in global geo-politics.

The second reason for this historiographic shift was disciplinary: during this period, Western historical practice was becoming increasingly professionalised and codified, with explicit methods of research and qualifications of expertise. The discipline shifted globally towards what Ian Tyrrell has described as a mode of 'Scientific History', where empirical archival research, attention to criticism and source analysis, as well as increasing professionalisation, came to define Historical Studies (Tyrrell 2005; Berlin 1960). Again, Australia was no exception. Universities appointed history professors, school systems commissioned history textbooks and governments institutionalised systems of education, including the teaching and learning of history.

The two trends—of disciplinary professionalisation and national expression—were intimately entwined, as Georg Iggers (2005, 475) has explained, noting 'the close relationship between the emergent historical profession in the nineteenth century, nationalism, and the nation-state'. Nations needed history to make sense; history, meanwhile, relied on that national narrative for enabling and verifying its disciplinary authority. In Australia, this moment of national and disciplinary foundation saw the appointment of the first Professor of History in 1890 (George Arnold Wood, to the University of Sydney), the first locally commissioned Australia history textbooks, and national independence in 1901. Yet that coalescing of the discipline with national consciousness created a curious temporality in Australian historiography. On the one hand, burgeoning Australian sentiment constantly invoked its nascent history, promoting a form of popular, celebratory historical consciousness. Meanwhile, the historical progress evident in colonial histories became even more strident in historiography from this period around federation, as historians crafted detailed

narratives of advancement to orient the nation towards the future. 'National time' was at once nostalgic and aspirational.

Partly that paradox was a response to what Stefan Berger has described as the settler-colonies' 'problem with historical time', in which 'locating the origins of their nations in the dim and distant past' was a conscious challenge (Berger 2007, 5; Iggers 2005; Sluga 2013; Hobsbawm 1990; Klein 1999; Mandler 2002; Tyrrell 2005). (Compared to the long narrative of its imperial metropole, Australia's settler-colonial history was but fleeting; furthermore, any attempt to assert its deep past extended the nation uncomfortably into its Indigenous history.) If anything, this perceived historical 'shortfall' amplified expressions of national historical consciousness. The new nation *needed* history. The 1901 foundation of the Australian Historical Society in New South Wales, along with similar organisations on Victoria (1909), and Queensland (1913) can be seen in this context, where a growing interest in the nation's past was both a celebration and a determination to demonstrate its validity (Daley 1939; Cramp 1917).¹ Australians were beginning 'to institutionalise their remembering and forgetting of the past', to borrow Bain Attwood's (2017, 32) description of this moment: 'records were increasingly preserved, museums built, societies founded, holidays created, commemorations held, monuments raised, curricula developed, and children instructed'.

Tied to that historical celebration and reminiscence was a constant invocation of the nation's historical progress: Australian history texts from the late nineteenth and first half of the twentieth centuries advanced endless tallies of expanding wool exports, cropped acres, and population growth (Coghlan 1918; Portus 1955). Even their titles, like Edward Combes' *Material Progress of New South Wales* (1885-6) and Timothy Coghlan and Thomas Ewing's *Progress of Australasia in the Nineteenth*

¹ It became the Royal Australian Historical Society in 1918.

Century (1902), the latter published to coincide with federation, make that historical logic of advancement, industry and agency overt. Inside their covers, the sense of development and inevitability was just as profound: 'In nearly every respect the record of the industrial life of Australia has been one of continuous progress', Coghlan and Ewing (1902, 309-10) announced.

The paradoxical temporality of national time is also visible here: Australian histories from the late nineteenth century until the middle decades of the twentieth tended to locate that national narrative in ways that celebrated the past *and* looked towards the future. In his 1909 *History of Australasia*, for example, Arthur Jose summarised the historical arc of the new nation: 'To this point, then, the course of Australian history has led us—that we hold a whole continent of valuable land'. But it was a historical assessment with one eye turned firmly to the future, as Jose simultaneously urged Australians to 'take seriously in hand the developing of our country's natural resources, by cultivating its richer soils, irrigating its drier, exploiting the fisheries along its coasts, opening up and thoroughly working the mines hidden below its surface' (Jose 1909, 250-1).

The effects of this reification of historical progress served to further exclude Indigenous people from historical time. Not only did history now have the 'evidence' to rationalise that occlusion, some historians even deployed linear time to demonstrate the 'cost' of colonisation for Indigenous peoples was far outweighed by that very progress. Alexander Sutherland's 1888 history of Victoria (published to coincide with the centenary of Australia's colonisation), was explicit in his accounting of the effects of historical 'progress' on Indigenous people: 'to the sentimental it is undoubtedly an iniquity; to the practical it represents a distinct step in human progress, involving the sacrifice of a few thousands of an inferior race; he subtracts that as a small drawback to a vast good, and finds the balance enormously on the side of the good' (Sutherland 1888, 29). Fifty years later, Archibald Meston's (1941,

115-6) history of Australia for school children continued to justify that omission as a matter of practical evidence: 'Our Aborigines hardly count. They are so few in number, keep to themselves and are fast dying out.'

Historical 'progress' was verified by the discipline's own 'scientific' apparatus of facts and evidence that were accumulating in its growing museum, library and archival collections. Furthermore, increasing disciplinary refinement reified the discipline's temporal borders, which had profound historiographical consequences in Australia. A survey of school History texts from that period shows that time was understood and deployed in ways which ensured Indigenous people remained outside both the national narrative and the discipline. G.V. Portus's (1955, 155-16) *Australia Since 1606* was first published in 1932 and describes pre-contact Australian history as a 'dark night', implying that History had not yet begun there. Russel Ward's popular school text, *Man Makes History* [see fig. 1], was similarly categorical. Despite being the oldest continuous civilisation in the world, Aboriginal people 'know almost no History', he explained (Ward 1952, 2).

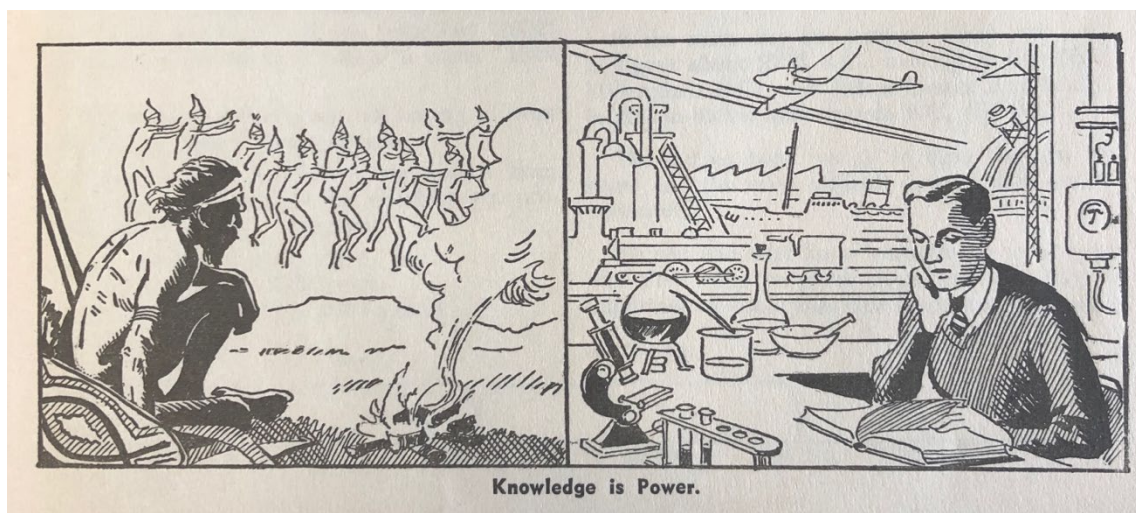


Fig 1. 'Knowledge is Power' (from Russell Ward, *Man Makes History*, Shakespeare Head Press: Sydney, 1952, p. 9)

Even histories that acknowledged the significance of Indigenous occupation prior to colonisation plotted that occupation in terms which sat outside the boundaries of empirical history. G.W. Rusden said as much in his 1883 *History of Australia*: 'How long the Aborigines of Australia had roamed over its soil when Europeans first explored the coast, it is for ethnologists to discuss—perhaps with no result' (Rusden 1883, 2). When the New South Wales Director General of Education gave the annual lecture to the Australian Historical Society in 1916, he similarly excluded Aboriginal history from the emerging national story that began, he determined, with the 'origin of settlement here in 1788 (for what took place before that is geographical rather than human history)' (Board 1916, 291). Meanwhile, 'pre-history' was left to the geologists, ethnologists, archaeologists and palaeontologists. Expanding scientific knowledge and interest in Australia's ancient human history demonstrated that the continent itself was far from empty—but it also clarified that the discipline of Australian history only began at the point of its European story.

The specification of Australian historiography meant that even living Indigenous people were methodically relegated to a distant past (Way 2022; Hunt 2013). 'The Central Australian aborigine is the living representative of a stone age, who still fashions his spear-heads and knives from flint or sandstone and performs the most daring surgical operations with them', William Austin Horn described in his 1895 history of Australian exploration. 'His origin and history are lost in the gloomy mists of the past. He has no written records and few oral traditions' (Horn 1895, 92).

In other words, Indigenous people became the *temporal evidence* of modern Australia's own advancement. As Tom Griffiths (1996, 45) has detailed, 'it was commonly thought' that Aboriginal people 'had no history'. Rather, they 'were caught in the fatal thrall of nature's continental museum'. Archaeologists Ian McNiven and Lynette Russell describe this temporality as a form of 'antiquation'. 'Australian Aborigines were not simply perceived as an unchanging people in a faraway land,'

they explain, but ‘rather they were represented as a relic of Europe’s own past and thus were imbued with both great antiquity and timeless stasis’ (McNiven and Russell 2005, 8, 52; Lydon 2019). Again, this curious, inconsistent temporality is visible, in which history is used to illuminate the past, but also create an explicit hierarchy between modern and ancient Australia.

This is not to say there were no histories by or about Indigenous people during this period. Powerful protests by Aboriginal activists such as William Cooper, Jack Patten, Bill Ferguson and Pearl Gibbs, which culminated in the famous 1938 Day of Mourning, demonstrate how Indigenous forms of history-making were active in Australia during the decades following federation (Markus 2011; Patten and Ferguson 1937; Horner and Langton 1987; Souter 1987). Meanwhile, historical works by creative writers such as Xavier Herbert (1938), Eleanor Dark (1946) and Judith Wright (1945), also sought to expose and include Indigenous people and perspectives into Australian historical consciousness. Overwhelmingly, however, these interventions were made outside the formal history discipline.

Decolonising time

In the decades following World War II, nearly two centuries after Australia’s colonisation began, a wave of historical revision increasingly questioned the discipline’s temporal assumptions regarding its ‘timeline’ and linear tropes of ‘progress’. Again, a wider context of this shift is critical to understanding the historiographical implications in Australia: internationally, a wave of decolonisation across South and East Asia as well as through the Pacific prompted new histories of empires and nations. This body of Postcolonial and Settler-Colonial Studies presented vital sub-altern and Indigenous perspectives, as well as parsing the colonising architecture of the history discipline, including its conceptualisations of time (Satiya 2020; Banivanua Mar 2016; Spivak 1988).

While Australia did not de-colonise, *per se*, the war also forced a reassessment of its place in the British Empire and its own national independence. Successive Australian governments in the 1950s and 1960s looked to build capacity and national security through infrastructure development, mass migration and expansion of the education system (Macintyre 2010; 2015; Forsyth 2014; Lee 1944). Along with these institutional and governmental forms of nation-building, a corresponding sense of Australia's unique cultural identity and heritage was also apparent. This period of post-war reconstruction saw a surge in Australian historical scholarship and output that was explicitly national in focus. The 'growing strength of national boundaries was unmistakable', Stuart Macintyre (1999, 177) described in a survey chapter on Australian historiography in an international context. For 'most historians of Australia, the Empire was of interest insofar as it bore on evolution of the colonies towards independent nationhood and no further'.

As Macintyre (1999, 172) explained, 'A nationalism that was no longer synonymous with imperialism required a new kind of national history'. To that end, the continent's ancient human history and ongoing Indigenous cultural expression were increasingly seen as a source of Australia's national distinctiveness, rather than an example of social and cultural hierarchies that justified imperialism as evolutionary and inevitable. It was a profound shift in the discipline's relationship with historical time.

In 1956, for example, the archeologist John Mulvaney led an excavation of Fromm's Landing, a cave overlooking the Murray River in South Australia, which utilised radiocarbon dating for the first time in Australia and pointed to occupation of that site stretching back 5,000 years. The date confirmed Australia's human history reached well beyond any sort of conventional documentary record and it registered a huge shift in the established 'beginnings' of Australian history. Mulvaney's publication of a *Pre-history of Australia* in 1968 further stretched the

nation's timeline into the deep past and sought to highlight the complexity and resilience of Aboriginal culture, despite the nineteenth-century histories which had predicted otherwise (Mulvaney 1958; 1969). His opening sentence in that 1969 volume was an explicit rejection of those historians who claimed Europeans had 'discovered' New Holland: 'The discoverers, explorers and colonists of the three million square miles which are Australia, were its Aborigines' (Mulvaney 1969, 15). Australian history did not begin with first contact, Mulvaney implored, and Australians' ignorance of the nation's Indigenous history diminished their capacity to understand themselves.

Twenty years later, after several more excavations led by Mulvaney, as well as the geologist Jim Bowler's famous work at Lake Mungo in south-western New South Wales, the date of Aboriginal occupation was pushed back even further—to 40,000 years. By the early twenty-first century, as Billy Griffiths' (2018) work into the history of Australian archaeology has shown, Indigenous claims that they had 'always been here' did not seem unreasonable alongside colossal timescales that now measure their presence at 65,000 BCE (McGrath, Rademaker and Silverstein 2021).

As the timeline of Australian history was pulled into unfamiliar eons, a simultaneous process of historical reappraisal and revision questioned why Indigenous people had been largely overlooked in the nation's settler-colonial history. The 1960s and 1970s saw growing claims for Indigenous rights and recognition from Indigenous activists, writers and historians, such as Oodgeroo Noonuccal (1966; 1981), Kevin Gilbert (1973; 1978) and Gary Foley (2011), who demanded land rights, social justice and political representation. They also pushed against the curation of Indigenous people by Australian historians, who, perversely, had condemned them to the past *and* excluded them from it.

Critique of the history discipline was also finding voice among non-Indigenous academics and public intellectuals. In 1967, the eminent anthropologist W. E. H.

Stanner gave his now famous Boyer Lectures, in which he argued that the exclusion of Indigenous people from Australian history was not inevitable, but a deliberate process of omission. Australia's sense of its past, its very collective memory, had been built on a pattern of forgetting, which could not 'be explained by absent mindedness', Stanner insisted. 'It is a structural matter, a view from a window which has been carefully placed to exclude a whole quadrant of the landscape' (Stanner 1967, 25).

By the 1970s, that growing critique had become a whole-scale historical revision, which not only advocated for the urgent inclusion of Indigenous histories and perspectives but also new historical methods to do so. 'The framework of our historical comprehension has been widened in recent years', Bob Reece (1979, 274) acknowledged in a survey of Australian Indigenous history in 1979. 'But a great deal more needs to be done if we are to eradicate the tenacious tradition that Australian history began with captain Cook and the First Fleet'.

While the decolonising moment following World War II was experienced unevenly across the world and took place over many decades, the historiography that moment produced was profound and influential. In particular, histories produced in postcolonial and settler-colonial contexts sought to explore and expose the discipline's complicity in structures of imperialism and colonialism. Part of that process, as Phillip J. Deloria has noted, was the growing 'recognition that academic research has a long, shameful history of compounding the evils of colonialism' (Deloria 2020, 538; Johnson 2020, 423; Anderson 2020).

'Time' is a powerful marker of that colonising frame, as Priya Satia's (2020) recent work has demonstrated. With its 'metanarrative of progress', to use Chakrabarty's memorable phrase (1997, 50), the history discipline established markers of historical time and measures of progress that have relegated the 'history-poor' to the fringes of its narratives. And yet, vital histories continued to made

outside the discipline from colonised and enslaved peoples: ‘However odd this might sound to readers of a collection on world history, millions of people still live outside “history”’, Ashis Nandy (1995, 44) contends. ‘They *do* have theories of the past; they *do* believe that the past is important and shapes the present and the future, but they also recognise, confront, and live with a past different from that constructed by historians and historical consciousness. They even have a different way of arriving at that past.’

As well as revealing the structures of imperial power that history helped to establish and maintain, that reappraisal of historical time also posed important challenges for the discipline. For example, how might historical conceptions of time be revised to include diverse peoples and temporalities? If universal assumptions of historical time are just that, as Arif Dirlik (2002) has advised, how does a discipline of inquiry, forged in Enlightenment principles of empiricism, evidence and rationality, as well as national teleologies, incorporate the histories of peoples who existed (and continue to exist) outside that disciplinary logic? ‘Is it possible’, as Mohammed S. Ali (2021, 280) has asked, ‘to mark time in a language that expresses its full heterogeneity?’ Warwick Anderson (2020, 438) has been similarly confronted by such questions: ‘can our historical imagination ever depart—becoming truly *decolonial*—from the terrain that colonialism has tilled so thoroughly?’

They are not easy questions to answer, Chakrabarty noted (2011, 244-45), reflecting on his own encounter with Indigenous Deep Time history as a scholar trained in empiricism:

I still remember my surprise and wonderment at encountering the subject called ‘Aboriginal history’ in Australia in the late 1970s and the early 1980s, where what was being called ‘history’ could only stretch over the 200 years of white occupation of the land. Beyond that, historical time like a sea beach that

abruptly develops a steep gradient suddenly dropped away into the depths of pre-history and archaeology where narratives went over much larger chunks of time (thousands of years sometimes) with astonishing rapidity and where scientific procedures like radiocarbon dating took matters beyond the social or cultural historian's competence!

Even when history does reach into Indigenous and pre-colonial temporalities, Ali writes, there is the risk that it forces a Western, disciplinary temporality on these pasts (Ali 2021, 290).

The Wiradjuri writer and poet, Jeanine Leane (2015, 151), explains this disconnect that lies at the heart of Australian historiography. 'The construct of "history" defines time as a space that can be measured', she explains. 'Time flows in a certain linear direction where people "make" history.' Meanwhile, Indigenous temporalities exist and function outside chronological disciplinary schema, as this Yanyuwa community collaboration from the Gulf Country of northern Australia explains:

Yanyuwa people, before modern times, did not have a word for history... History as we know it in Western ontology and epistemology seeks to maintain an exact, impersonal, record of past events. Instead, the Yanyuwa have the word *linginmantharra* - remembering or being mindful, or *linginmanthanima* - to remember and be mindful of all the things that country can contain: species, particular names, ancestors, ceremony and song, ways of behaving and knowing, and the way they all articulate together (Bradley and Yanyuwa Families 2010).

Does History—the Western, empirical, chronologically ordered discipline—have the capacity to incorporate such Indigenous histories, Indigenous historians ask

(Kyamullina and Kwaymullina 2010)? Echoing Yanyuwa expressions of time, the Yolŋu concept of ‘songspirals’ explains vast song-stories that stretch into a deep and ancestral time, as well as extending to the present. In the words of the Gay’wu Group of Women, Yolŋu knowledge-holders from Arnhem Land in far north Australia, songspirals are ‘infinite’. They ‘spiral, connecting and remaking. They twist and turn, they move and loop. This is like all our songs. Our songs are not a straight line. They do not move in one direction through time and space’ (Gay’wu Group of Women 2019, xvi).

Clearly, there is a question of whether Australian Indigenous texts—drawn in sand, sung, painted and walked on Country—can be rendered into chronological historical discourse, since their very *logics* are so different. In the words of Ngemba man, Brad Steadman, ‘The Western concept [of time] is illogical to us’ (cit. Clark 2022, 282). Critically, the consequences of this disconnect are political as well as epistemological. As Krim Bentarrak, Stephen Muecke and Goolarabooloo elder, Paddy Roe (2014, 144), insist, ‘Within the issue of Aboriginal sovereignty there is more at stake than the use of lands; there is the right to control the production of Australia’s mythologies.’ Could Indigenous interventions in Australia’s historical time shift settler-colonial entitlement, as well as its narratives?

Such questions highlight a growing acknowledgement of history’s capacity to relegate and silence, while also offering possibilities for imaginative and inclusive readings of the past. Work by Australian Indigenous historians, writers, and creative practitioners, such as Tony Birch, Marcia Langton, Jonathan Jones, Heidi Norman, and Jeanine Leane, as well as co-created and collaborative studies of ‘Creative Histories’ (Lindsey et al. 2022; Birch 2013; Leane 2015; 2018), offer important insight into how history might contemplate the challenges of disciplinary decolonisation. To borrow from the Aotearoa-New Zealand historian Miranda Johnson, these ‘hyphenated histories’ (using fiction, testimony and linguistic diversity) have the capacity to

extend the discipline and understand pasts and perspectives which have been occluded (Johnson 2020). These approaches extend the discipline, while also representing a radical break, and provide space where foundational concepts such as 'time' are imagined and deployed in new ways.

Examples of disciplinary hybridity can also be seen in research by non-Indigenous history-makers, such as William Gallois (2017), Michelle Bastian (2009; 2013), Judith Binney (2004), Ross Gibson (2012), and Greg Denning (1998), who have experimented with registers of time and historical agency as a way of overcoming the hegemonic tendencies of the history discipline to reinforce established archives, narratives and expertise. Describing histories of entanglement and contact in the Pacific, for example, Denning (1998, 146) emphasised the need to expand historical practice in order to tell more encompassing stories of empire and colonisation (when its own archives only partially remember them).

While ventures into Deep Time and Indigenous epistemologies might temper the discipline's erasure of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander history, historians also need to resist cultural prescriptions that understand Indigenous history-making as only non-linear or ancient (Wolfe, 1991). After all, the 'meaning of the past—*history*—is something Indigenous communities have an enormous stake in', Canadian First Nations scholar, Michael Marker similarly insists. Indigenous demands for historical 'truth-telling' in Australia also demonstrate that the discipline does not have sole claim on empirical truth and evidence (Uluru 2017). History has failed to tell the Indigenous experience of Australia, as Aboriginal legal academic Megan Davis (Davis and Appleby 2018; Davis 2018a; Davis 2018b) insists. Its very disciplinary structures tend to exclude Indigenous experiences and voices. As such, Indigenous people have been effectively disenfranchised from the very history they have lived through, argue Australian Indigenous scholars Aileen Moreton-Robinson and Martin Nakata (2007).

Narrative and chronological uncertainty might highlight some of the challenges of ‘decolonising time’, yet even that uncertainty represents a notable contrast from the temporal confidence of early Australian historiography and confirms the need to historicise ‘historical time’. Can Indigenous cosmologies offer new temporalities to Australian history? Does ‘Australian historiography’ begin with the earliest forms of Indigenous history making? How can history—that Western empirical discipline—reach into the deep past, when the only historical records are oral, embodied, and held in landscapes? Any answer illuminates not only our sense of historical time, but the ways we understand and do history at a point *in time*.

Conclusion

This article has reviewed the concept of ‘time’ in Australian history by examining the various ways time has been considered, contemplated and mobilised *over time*. Drawing on international theoretical interventions to re-read time in Australian historiography, it reveals how the meaning of historical time has shifted. The image of the ‘progress’ of a young and vibrant British civilisation on an ancient, apparently unhistoried land was a recurring theme in Australian historiography until the mid-to late-twentieth century, when the pressures of Indigenous histories finally rendered that retelling untenable. By the latter decades of the twentieth century, Australian history’s timeline and its logic of national progress was challenged from within the discipline and without. This growing intervention has not only allowed us to see that ‘understandings of time and history are culturally and historically embedded’, as Marnie Hughes-Warrington (2009, 569-70) explains, but that ‘the activity of historiography itself is also embedded.’ Just as ‘time’ can colonise, and nationalise, this paper also canvases how the concept can form a vital part of a disruptive, ethical intervention into the history discipline, offering new research agendas and new theoretical frames of analysis. In turn, it also presents a narrative of historical time

in Australian historiography, contributing to growing understandings of the history of history.

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